

WHERE DID ALL THE DEBATERS GO? STRATEGIES FOR DEVELOPING RELATIONSHIPS BETWEEN HIGH SCHOOL AND COLLEGE PROGRAMS

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Abstract: One role of collegiate program directors and coaches that is often overlooked is the role of developing relationships with the local high school community. Due to time and resource constraints, collegiate directors may leave recruiting to students. As college directors and coaches, the inconsistency in professional ties between the collegiate and high school community is an issue that needs further exploration and specific action. This essay explores the case for engagement with high schools, briefly explore the differences among the varied high school and collegiate debate circuits, and provides some strategies for developing mutually beneficial long-term relationships.

In the 2007 film, *The Great Debaters*, Wiley College's debate program holds tryouts for their competitive collegiate debate team. No fewer than 45 of the school's 360 students try out four spots available (two for the top team and two alternates). Later, when the team tastes success, Wiley holds pep rallies in their honor, and is regaled by marching bands. Needless to say, this level of interest and involvement would shock even the most successful of contemporary coaches. The idea that so many students would be out for debate—and that

so many would be turned away—is a laughable anachronism in 21st century policy debate. While the depiction of interest in the team might be increased for dramatic effect, and the students were given an opportunity not often afforded to students at historically black colleges in Texas during the 1920s and 30s, that level of debate participation is not seen on modern debate squads. Although returning to the participation of Wiley College's glory days is a long way off, there are a number of common sense ideas that if prioritized, can help collegiate programs while helping high school communities as well.

With the exception of a few squads, most debate programs struggle to recruit members and maintain substantial participation. As directors and coaches, recruiting is sporadic at best, without a systematic and organized approach to developing relationships with the local high school community. Because of that failure to recruit consistently, high school debaters are often unaware of the diverse opportunities to debate in college (Cheshier, 2000; Luong, 2002; Reppert, 1991), and collegiate programs miss out on students willing and able to compete at the highest levels. In order to serve both their own interests and expand the educational opportunities debate at all levels offers; coaches and directors of collegiate programs can and should play a larger role in the high school debate community to ensure that students who are interested in collegiate debate have the opportunity to continue their competitive careers.

This essay argues that collegiate coaches and directors can and should work to improve relationships with high school debate coaches and students; engaging high school debate in a more systematic manner. Additionally diversity of high school debate needs to be appreciated to maximize the assistance that the collegiate community can provide. In order to elaborate

on our approach, we first explore the case for engagement with high schools, briefly explore the differences among the varied high school and collegiate debate circuits, and provide some strategies for developing mutually beneficial long-term relationships.

Reasons for engagement

For a college coach or director, spending another weekend at a tournament is exhausting. However, an active presence on the high school circuit can be a crucial difference-maker for a college program. Perhaps the best evidence is the example of the involvement in the high school community by the late Ross Smith, who showed that college directors who are an active and an identifiable presence in the high school community serve as an exceptional recruiting tool for their collegiate programs. Especially if a team is rebuilding or small, it may not be on the radar of the local high school circuit, and effort may be necessary to attract interested, experienced debaters. Collegiate and high school tournaments rarely intersect and frequently occur simultaneously, so there is an understandable lack of comprehension on both sides. However, the experience of Urban Debate Leagues has shown that there is great potential for the merging of collegiate and secondary debate interests (Ziegelmueller, 1998). The late Scott Deatherage's work with the National Association of Urban Debate Leagues demonstrates there is an interest in developing good relationships between a variety of high school communities and collegiate directors. Also, an active presence allows collegiate coaches to understand the local high school circuit and thus better identify recruiting matches for the team. Attending tournaments is also a way to increase professional service and improve a vita; most universities treasure professors who are actively involved in recruiting. Working with a department chair or admissions office on

recruiting can help build a case for a debate coach's necessity on campus.

There are a few important reasons for direct, regular engagement with the high school community on a local level. First, there are misconceptions on the part of high school and collegiate communities. To begin with, many coaches are not especially familiar with the high school circuit in their area. There may be stylistic differences from NDT/CEDA debate, and college personnel may overlook students who compete in non-policy debate who may be excellent prospects, but do not attend a high school that has a policy team. Unlike the collegiate circuit, where students can choose their school based on a multitude of criteria, high school students usually attend their local school, and may compete in policy debate only if it is available.

Another stumbling block for collegiate coaches is that they may view their local circuit through their high school experience. Most high school circuits have changed substantially in the last 10-15 years. Also high school teams and coaches might be subject to restrictions that collegiate programs are not. For instance, some states or school districts have rules of varying severity about when and how far teams can travel to compete. Some states allow policy debate competitions in only one semester per year. These are restrictions not placed on collegiate teams and may unfamiliar. If a director waits until the spring to recruit, there may be no debate going on in their region at all.

On the high school side, there are too misconceptions about collegiate programs. In some respects, practices by collegiate programs have created this atmosphere. Littlefield and Venette (2004) and Brand (1996) address the disconnection between the high school and college community. Dayton and Kay (2002) outline the negative perceptions of the collegiate judge. "Warranted or unwarranted, they are criticized

and stereotyped because some members don't dress professionally, they do not act professionally, they keep a professional relationship with competitors, they smoke, they curse, and they don't write educational critiques" (p. 75). Students may bring the more relaxed world of college debate into high schools, which in some cases, violates high school behavioral rules, such as smoking or drinking. If students do not act as ambassadors for their school, but instead treat judging as an extension of their weekend, their behavior will be unwelcome in an environment focused on serving a community of teenagers.

Not only are the behavioral issues from the college programs problematic, the expectation that high school debate can or should be "mini NDT/CEDA circuits" can create a rift with high school programs (Littlefield & Venette, 2004). Especially in areas that encourage more traditional forms of debate, a collegiate style of argument influenced by postmodern philosophy, technical skills, and disregard for the basic stock issues might be unwelcome in some communities (Smith, 1998). Along with these expectations on what constitutes high-level debate, some collegiate debaters and even coaches try to transfer their reputation from the collegiate circuit onto the high school circuit. Having a first round bid or being a frequent out-round team may not mean much to a high school coach or tab room that does not read the CEDA Forums. Finally, with the increase of term and visiting positions for collegiate debate coaches, there is a lot of turnover in collegiate programs. The local high school community may not be familiar with the current director. Without a strong relationship, a once-a-year recruiting visit might be perceived as purely self-interested and interpreted as a lack of real interest in the debate circuit.

These misconceptions between the high school and collegiate communities are unfortunate, because there are many benefits to both high school students and

coaches having a more friendly college-high school relationship. First, choosing to debate in college can help students make decisions about which college to attend. Especially if a student has interests in mainstream subjects, it may be hard for students to distinguish between which school would be the best fit for them. Moreover, for students, being recruited by a college coach may help them to distinguish themselves at elite universities. Instead of a college visit where they may or may not meet individually with professors, having a collegiate coach not only know their name, but also be able to work as an advocate with admissions decisions is extremely helpful. Not only can coaches help students get into schools, debate can help students be successful while in college. Luong (2002) explains: "Dedicated participation in drama and debate has significantly increased the success rate of college applications at all schools where they track such data" (p. 1). Part of the reason that students are successful is because debate team travel often requires a minimum G.P.A., the national tournaments require students to be in good standing to participate, and debate often has excellent networking opportunities for graduate school and work.

For high school coaches, a more active collegiate program can help the health of their community. For one, debate tournaments, especially at the high school level, perpetually look for experienced judging. Judges at the high school level are too few, too hard to recruit and retain, and in small circuits, are often restricted against judging many other teams. Provided that collegiate coaches and debaters have a good understanding with a high school circuit, they can provide judging resources that can turn any tournament into a fantastic learning experience. In addition, college teams can serve a critical role by hosting high school tournaments. These tournaments provide students the opportunity to have a neutral site to compete at, something that might be

essential at a state tournament. Also, hosting provides students, especially younger students, the opportunity to visit a college campus outside a traditional visit.

Diversity in High School and Collegiate Circuits

As good as college debate can be for high school debate, and vice versa, far too often unnecessary and petty hostilities and misunderstandings build barriers which serve no one's interest. Understanding the full depth and diversity of debate and all its different types of debate style, local, regional, and national circuits, and types of tournaments, is critical to building a foundation for strong relationships between high school and college programs. That understanding can serve as a guide to understanding what strategies will be successful and which are inappropriate for a given debate community. Each circuit is different and has its own eccentricities, but few cannot be cracked by the collegiate coach who approaches with humility and flexibility.

It is important to keep in mind that good debaters come from a variety of backgrounds. Not all successful NDT/CEDA debaters have a high school policy debate background, and even those with high school policy experience may not have had national level experience. Coaches and directors should look for students who are the best "fit" for their program and university/college, and keeping these considerations in mind is important when recruiting.

Different Types of High School Debate

Although cross-ex/policy debate in high school is the closest analog to NDT/CEDA debate, there are a wide variety of other events, which develop a similar skill set. Most collegiate directors are familiar with some of these events, including Lincoln-Douglas debate and extemporaneous speaking. In both of these events, debaters work by themselves. Lincoln Douglas debate

mimics policy debate's adversarial format, pitting two competitors against each other in directly clashing speeches and cross-examinations. This event's topic usually requires competitors to construct affirmative and negative cases, and each side participates in cross examination, and each side delivers a rebuttal. Although Lincoln-Douglas debaters typically debate value questions rather than policy questions, there is no evidence to suggest that debaters with high school Lincoln-Douglas experience are substantially unprepared for high-level debate compared to those with high school policy experience.

Extemporaneous speaking might be more properly conceived of as an individual event within forensics activity, but the skills it promotes are very similar to policy debate. It requires extensive research, organization, argument formation, and knowledge of current events. Students are given a topic and a limited amount of time to prepare a 7-10 minute speech. Students deliver a memorized speech with source citations from research that their team has collected. Again, although extemporaneous speaking differs from policy debate, as it avoids an adversarial structure, it can still be a fine preparation for policy debate at the collegiate level.

Two events that have dramatically risen in popularity in the high school circuit in the past decade are Student Congress and Public Forum. Student Congress has been around for a long time, but its popularity has ballooned in recent years. Whereas it was once relegated to the end of the season for debaters and extempers to get a second chance at NFL qualification, it now has a dedicated set of students who have opportunities to compete all year. Student Congress mimics the legislative process. Students research and write bills, debate them in competition, and cross-examine each other. A relatively new event on the high

school circuit is Public Forum. Public Forum is a form of debate that was designed for accessibility to a layperson, but otherwise, mimics the structure of policy debate in a shortened format. The emphasis in Public Forum is on utilizing persuasive appeals and delivery style, as opposed to policy debate, which tends to be judged based on evidence and argument development. Public Forum has increased in popularity in recent years, and as seen as a less time and resource intensive activity. It provides opportunities to debate for schools that do not have a dedicated policy debate coach.

It is easy for practitioners of policy debate to look down on other, less intense forms of competition as insufficiently educational. However, regardless of one's opinion of these events, their popularity indicates that they are here to stay, and thus, a collegiate director cannot afford to overlook or disrespect these events. Collegiate directors cannot afford to be intolerant of debate on the high school level. Given the difficulties faced in retaining high school policy students on the collegiate level, coaches and directors must broaden their recruitment pool and support all forms of debate at the high school level. For example, hosting a high school tournament that only includes policy debate at the exclusion of other events risks alienating potential recruits and programs who either do not compete in policy or who have large numbers of students in non-policy events. Hosting a big tent tournament increases the likelihood that single-coach teams might attend because all of their students can compete there, instead of just a small fraction. In some cases, it is possible that debaters who participate in some of these events might even be a better market for collegiate debate because they have not been burned out on policy debate in high school, and may be hungry for a more rigorous experience. Understanding and supporting these alternate forms of debate not only can improve the

relationship between high school and college debate circuits, but also can serve to broaden college debate's range of applicants.

Diversity in High School Debate Circuits

Just as the diversity in forms of high school debate demand understanding and tolerance from collegiate directors hoping to improve their relationship with high school programs, the range of diversity within policy debate at the high school level demands the appreciation of collegiate coaches as well. Even though the format of cross-examination policy debate most closely mirrors NDT/CEDA debate (just a minute in speech times difference), the format of tournaments; before, during, and post-round expectations and etiquette; argument style; and even style of attire can make high school policy debate seem like another planet to collegiate directors and coaches. There is no simple or conclusive way to classify high school circuits, but awareness of and respect for the quirks of local circuits is critical to maintaining a relationship with a local high school circuit. The national and many regional and local high school circuits have already been greatly influenced by NDT/CEDA debate through the growing importance of debate institutes, returning collegiate debaters as coaches and judges, etc. While collegiate directors or coaches may garner some initial credibility by virtue of their position, building true credibility takes time and energy put into understanding and respecting the desires and expectations of the high school circuit.

In addition navigating these differences, given the changes in the high school circuit, it is important to be cognizant of two important trends: the disappearance of the local circuit in some areas and the increasing intensity of the national circuit. In some states, the local circuit is getting stronger. Places like Kansas, which, while it is a relatively small state in terms of population,

it boasts five National Forensics League Districts out of the 102 in the country ("District Chair", 2008). Not only do they have five districts, debate is well supported in the state at least in part because it is sanctioned by the state athletic commission, which means that schools have strong incentives to field debate teams. However, Kansas is not a typical example. In many states, debate and forensics are not as well supported as they were ten to fifteen years ago. From the authors' anecdotal observation, this is certainly the case in Ohio, Iowa, and Nebraska. Individual programs are faced with declining numbers of students. Consequently, even when programs decide to support local tournaments, they have few teams to send there. When there are fewer teams on the local circuit, it dramatically decreases the numbers at local tournaments, which means that teams with resources will seek out regional or national tournaments and the local tournaments shrink or stop happening altogether. In many cases, and even over short amounts of time, the size and culture of circuits can change dramatically. In terms of participation, fewer schools are competing in policy debate. For instance, if an active director of a high school program retires and he or she is not replaced, or their retirement is used as an opportunity to reallocate funds, their absence can have an effect on the programs around that school. In these cases, respect for the growth of other forms of debate is necessary, but efforts to increase and support efforts to reestablish the importance of policy debate are often appreciated as well.

In terms of culture, some areas discourage disclosure of decisions, or even provision of judges who are experts in policy debate (Smith, 1998). Even the level of post-round discussion can vary in its extent. There are situations where there might be confusion between what a judge thinks is helpful feedback and what a coach believes is the role of the critic. The key is to be

respectful of the style of debate in the region. Each region or district may have a specific set of standards that they follow, which are often unstated.

These issues are important to consider on a local circuit. Judging and recruiting on the national circuit presents a unique set of challenges. Tournament of Champions (TOC) refers to an annual tournament hosted by the University of Kentucky for debaters who travel the national circuit. To be successful on this circuit, debaters must employ a specific style of debate that is similar to the national circuit in college. TOC qualifying tournaments are frequent—because of the prestige and perceived higher quality of debate, more high schools are traveling regularly on a regional and national level. Different regions host these tournaments to provide more opportunities for schools from different regions to attempt to qualify. For instance, during the 2008-09 season, there were 45 TOC bid eligible policy debate tournaments throughout the country, including seven in California, six in Texas, and four in Georgia (“2010 National High”, 2009). While it is not surprising that these states, with substantial NFL participation and population centers, have multiple TOC bids, of the 48 continuous states that host NFL policy debate, 22 of them hold TOC bid policy debate tournaments (“2010 National High”). While this circuit provides excellent opportunities for its participants, a student on a team that travels this frequently could spend a full month of their school year traveling and competing at these tournaments, not including local, district qualifying, and the state tournaments. This time does not include individual and team debate work, AP classes, and other homework, as well as other activities. Some students thrive on this schedule and many former NDT champions, participants, and successful college debaters are a product of this system. After four years of the high school national circuit, a debater is well prepared for the

rigorous schedule, and level of competition at a national collegiate NDT/CEDA program. But having such an intense schedule, especially at such a young age, can discourage students from continuing their policy debate career in college.

Strategies for Engaging High School Debate

#1 The director, coach, and students needs to be a positive presence in the high school community

This directive might seem unrealistic, given the hectic travel schedule of a director. Especially with a family or active personal life, this might be difficult, but directors and coaches must make some efforts in this area, even if it means attending only part of a tournament. The director or the coach is the representative of the program, he or she must set the tone for their students who are recruiting, as well as play a critical role as spokesperson and representative of the team.

#2 Judge high school debates

For a coach or director, this means attending at least some high school tournaments over a season. Be active in these visits: interact with high school coaches, judges, and debaters. Volunteer to judge at least a couple of rounds, if serving as a judge for the entire tournament is impossible. Directors and coaches should judge debates at the high school level for several reasons: 1.) It can improve understanding of what the state of debate is in the circuit, 2.) it is a far superior method of recruiting students than approaching them based on recommendations, and 3.) it signals to high school coaches and tournaments that the college program is willing to help serve the high school community as well as its own interests. Be willing to judge Lincoln-Douglas, Public Forum, and individual events, as well as policy debates.

#3 Host tournaments on university or college campuses

In addition to attending high school tournaments, directors and coaches can engage the high school debate circuit in other ways as well. Where there are dates open in the high school schedule, offer to run inclusive tournaments. Bringing students to a college campus is a great recruiting tool. Beware, however, of the tendency towards exclusivity, or of stepping on the toes of high school programs who may be running concurrent tournaments—there are few quicker ways to create hostility. Involving local high school coaches in the planning and administration of a tournament ensures that their interests are met, and may lighten the college director's load as well. Find as many ways as possible to help high school coaches take advantage of the resources of the university or college—getting students on campus is rarely a negative.

#4 Encourage positive interactions between college debaters and high school debate communities

Perhaps the most important way to create a positive relationship between a collegiate debate program and the high school debate circuit is to ensure that college debaters interact positively with the high school community. The perceptions that many more conservative circuits have of college debater judges can be changed, if gradually (Pineda, 2000). Establish, explain, and enforce clear guidelines about how college student judges interact with high school debaters, judges, and coaches. Regardless of how good an example a director sets, the perception of college debate is also established by the debaters themselves. A reality of sending college debaters into a high school tournament is that they may need guidance in how to judge high school debates (Dayton & Kay, 2002). For experienced debaters, this idea may seem onerous and unnecessary. However,

understanding how to debate and how to be a judge are separate issues (Dayton & Kay). College judges must understand all the quirks and eccentricities of a high school circuit. If those standards mean that smoking and poor dress are not acceptable, those standards can be explained and enforced. If they mean that oral critiques or post-round disclosure are not acceptable, then college judges should respect those expectations. Both the director and student judges should avoid trying to turn a high school circuit into a mini-NDT. Aside from the diplomatic reasons, judging can be a daunting experience for new judges. Discuss how to evaluate rounds, deal with difficult post round discussions, and coaches. While much of good judging is going out and judging, providing college debaters with some framework for how to approach the experience opens the door to future conversations. It also begins a professional relationship as a colleague as opposed to a student-coach relationship. If a director is able to talk with students about the process of coaching and judging, they can learn to be more active in leadership roles on their own squad.

However, within the framework of the local circuit, college debaters also represent the greatest positive asset that college debate programs have. They can be encouraged to judge, since a surplus of experienced judges at local high school tournaments can be rare. In appropriate cases, college debaters should be encouraged to actively participate in the high school circuit as coaches (Reppert, 1991). Either through a service project or other work, students can contribute to helping high school teams, even with limited coaching. The key is to know when that help would be appreciated, and when it would be ill received.

Students are the best recruiters. Huebner and Fuller (1993) argue that "It almost goes without saying that students are often more equipped—because of experience, proximity in age, and understanding-level—

to develop the necessary kinds of relationships" (p. 6) Huebner and Fuller continue, arguing that students are often in the best position to explain the philosophy of a program, or what life on the team is like because they experience it on a daily basis. A coach can only be so self aware about themselves and their philosophy or coaching.

Another reason to include students in the process is that it teaches them to repay for the privilege of debating in high school (Stepp, 1996). If someone was a competitor in high school, that means that coaches, parents, and possibly even younger siblings, made that competition possible by running tournaments, judging and traveling with teams. Training undergraduate alumni to give back—during their collegiate careers and afterwards—can foster future good relations with college programs (Stepp).

The critical point to remember is that any person who can be connected to the university acts, willingly or not, as a representative to high school debate circuits. Reppert (1991) argues that debate team members need to be ambassadors of the community and should act appropriately. Even though college debaters or coaches may be hired as free agents for judging or administrating at a high school tournament, they must understand that part of their obligations to the collegiate squad is representing it in a way consistent with the overall goals of the program. These obligations and expectations can be formalized in squad rules or be made a part of scholarship agreements--even taking some time during a van drive to discuss good high school judging behavior can make a huge difference.

#6 Consult with individuals in the area

Part of learning about an area is drawing on information from a wide variety of coaches in the region. While it is easy to assume familiarity with an old high school circuit, the dynamics of high school debate are always shifting. Building and maintaining friendly relationships with new high school coaches is a good way to negotiate these dynamics (Brand, 1996). These discussions can provide a clearer picture of how the region functions and makes a director a better recruiter. For instance, if a squad requires students to generate their own evidence, it may not want to actively recruit a student from a program that is overly reliant on research assistants and coaches. Also, these consultations help determine when and what type of tournament would be most appropriate. Hosting a high school tournament is a great way to recruit, and a wonderful way to use a campus and team as a way to advertise for recruits (Glenn, 1991). It also helps establish credibility with students who haven't had direct contact with a program, and with novice and JV debaters. Making these plans in consultation with high school coaches over their schedule can help make a tournament a fantastic experience. For instance, the ideal weekend for a given program to host might be in April or May, well after the national tournament season. But most high school programs may be done with debate for the season after the state tournament in the winter and working on next year's topic already. Moreover, directors should ensure tournament does not conflict with an important tournament on the high school schedule. Just because a weekend works for one program in season, scheduling it against an important in-state tournament means a tournament will not be able to draw in teams to make a successful event, and may only offend those with whom cooperation is most desired.

Final Thoughts

While it may seem like a great deal of work in the short term, strong relationships with the high school debate community can save a great deal of work and worry. Recruitment, over time, can improve the college program and be a good resource for the high school community. After a school has established its credibility within the community and built up relationships, it should be easier to create recognition among a potential pool of recruits. If college debaters are alumnus of the high schools in the region, they can be great resources for high school students and coaches to have a better understanding of the collegiate program (Brand, 1996). Additionally, recruiting experienced debaters on a university squad can help alleviate the workload of college coaches. Experienced debaters can produce evidence as a first year student and save time with having to teach a first year debater about debate. Second, experienced debaters can work with novice debaters and serve as mentors on the team. It can be difficult to coach a squad where no one has experience; having a mix of experienced high school debaters and college novices is a good way to field a balanced team that can have some coaching provided by students. This peer coaching can take pressure off the coaching staff to teach every lesson about debate.

As policy debate continues into the 21st century, we who have benefited from debate have obligation to think about ways to work constructively with all debate communities to maximize cooperation and opportunities. High schools can produce high quality recruits for a program. But more importantly, high school and college coaches and directors are colleagues. We should work together to provide the best educational and competitive experience for the students that we serve by being active partners (Ziegelmueller, 1998). This is our responsibility to debate. If we learn nothing else from *The Great*

Debaters, we must remember that opportunities for debaters create opportunities for great positive change in the world.

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